

The Global Burden of Mental Illness



Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Hundreds of Millions Affected

1 in 3 women and 1 in 5 men will face major depression in their lifetime



Women

1 in 3

will experience major depression



Men

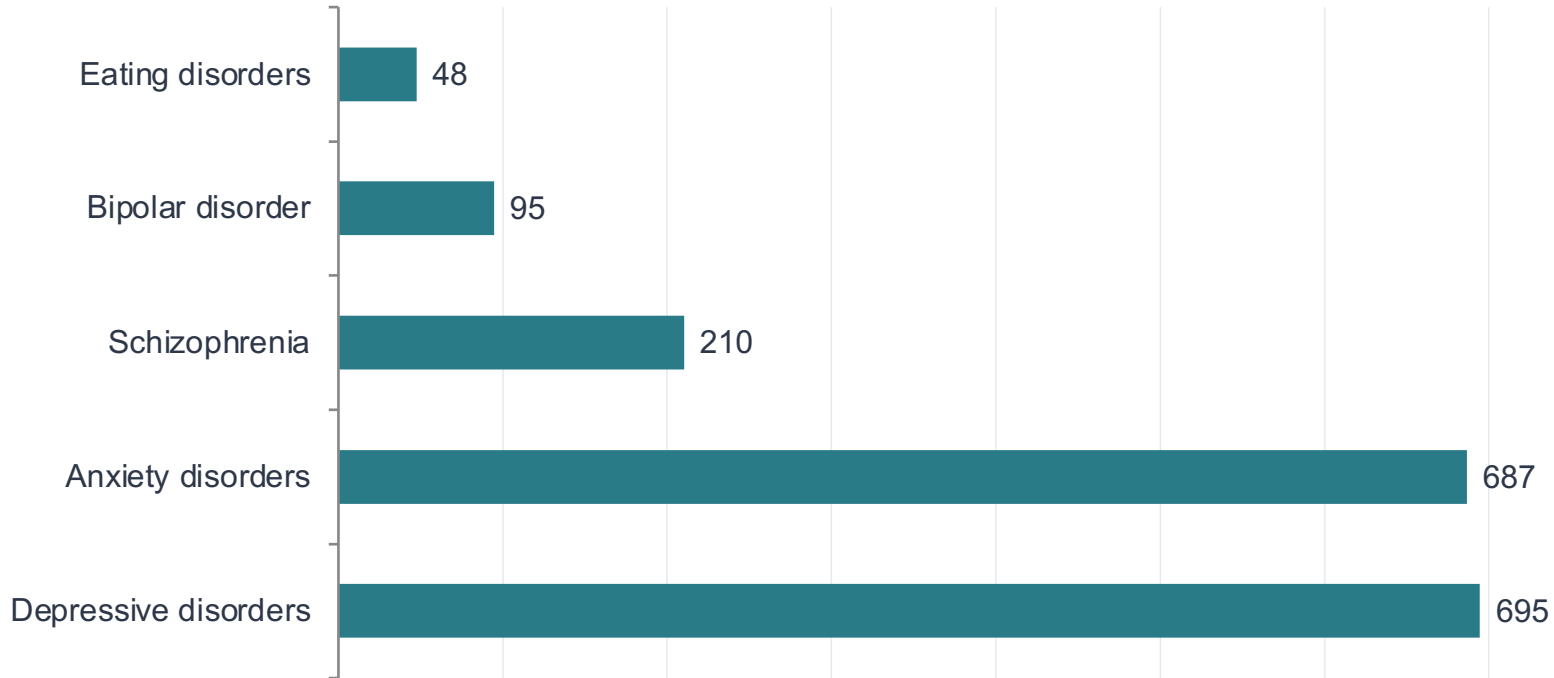
1 in 5

will experience major depression

Mental health conditions span from common (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar disorder). Understanding prevalence is essential for effective policy.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate

DALYs per 100,000 people by mental illness category, World, 2023



Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025) via Our World in Data

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden

Depressive
Disorders

694.6

DALYs per 100,000

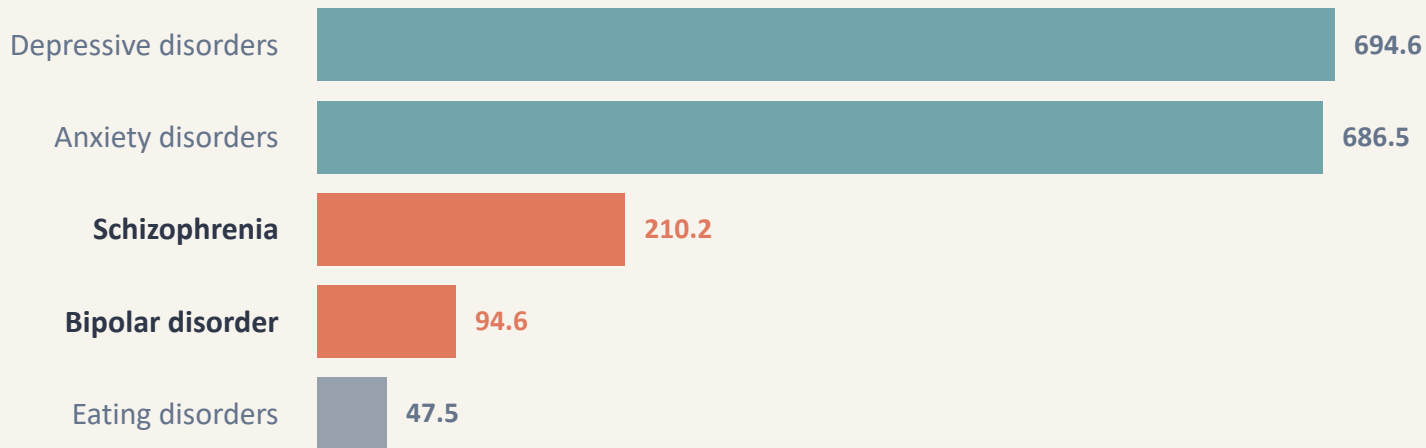
Anxiety
Disorders

686.5

DALYs per 100,000

Together, depression and anxiety account for roughly 80% of the total mental health disease burden across these five categories, dwarfing all other conditions.

Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact



While population-level burden is lower for schizophrenia and bipolar disorder, individual severity and disability are disproportionately high. Schizophrenia contributes 210.2 DALYs per 100,000 — reflecting the severe disability associated with the condition.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Mental illnesses are treatable, yet significant barriers prevent adequate care



Stigma

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or people they know



Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries



Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality



Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes true prevalence difficult to estimate — the actual burden may be higher

Good data is essential to understand these conditions — how, when, and why they occur, and how they can be treated effectively and safely.

How People Cope

From medication to faith to family conversations — coping strategies vary widely across countries



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where healthcare infrastructure and access to pharmaceuticals are more available



Religious & Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide, reflecting deep cultural and spiritual traditions in mental health



Talking to Friends & Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across cultures and income levels

The diversity of coping strategies underscores that mental health responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors. Policy interventions must account for these differences.

Key Takeaways

Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

- 01** | Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs
- 02** | Schizophrenia and bipolar carry disproportionate individual burden relative to prevalence
- 03** | Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate
- 04** | Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data
- 05** | Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions